ONYX LEDGER — MERGED PRODUCT ANALYSIS

Pros & cons of merging the Tax Health Score tool and the TaxOS / Copilot dashboard into one Canadian tax-filing startup · July 2026

Scope: This document evaluates the plan to merge the features of **onyxledgertaxhealth.netlify.app** (Tax Health Score questionnaire) and **onyxledgercopilot.netlify.app** (full TaxOS dashboard: filing workflow, AI copilot, decision simulators, document vault) into a single Canadian consumer tax-filing product. Both are currently frontend-only demos. **Green = pros. Red = cons and hard realities.** This review is deliberately critical — the goal is a product that survives contact with the market, not a flattering summary.

Bottom line up front: The merged concept is strategically coherent — a free diagnostic (Tax Health Score) feeding a year-round tax platform is a textbook acquisition funnel, and "year-round tax operating system" is genuinely underserved in Canada. But the plan as demoed is **80% vision, 20% moat**. The three things that will decide whether this works are none of the features on either site: (1) **NETFILE certification** — without it you are not a filing product at all; (2) **surviving a market where the best competitor is free** (Wealthsimple Tax); and (3) **liability containment for AI-generated tax guidance**. Merge the sites — that part is right — but treat the merge as the easy 10% of the problem.

1. WHAT IS ACTUALLY BEING MERGED

	Tax Health site	Copilot / TaxOS site
Role	Top-of-funnel: anonymous questionnaire producing an educational "Tax Health Score" with rough dollar illustrations. Carries proper disclaimers (not tax advice, not CRA-affiliated).	The product: dashboard with filing workflow (Collect → Analyse → Optimize → Review → File), document upload (T4/T5/T5008), refund estimate with confidence, RRSP/FHSA/capital-gains simulators, ONYX Copilot Q&A, security page, Free / $29.99 per return / $9.99 per month pricing.
State	Working static frontend.	Static frontend with hardcoded sample data (82/100 score, $2,431 refund). No backend, no tax engine, no CRA integration.

The merge thesis: the free score is the hook; the score's "opportunities" (+$420 medical, +$180 work-from-home) convert users into the paid platform; the simulators and copilot keep them engaged year-round instead of once per April.

2. PROS — WHAT THIS APPROACH GETS RIGHT

PRO — The funnel structure is correct and proven.
Free diagnostic → personalized gap ("you're leaving ~$600 on the table") → paid product that closes the gap. This is the Credit Karma / NerdWallet playbook and it works because the score creates a concrete, personal

reason to sign up. A quiz is also cheap top-of-funnel content that can rank for search and be shared. Keeping the score free and low-friction (no account required to see a result) is the right call.

PRO — "Year-round tax OS" attacks the real weakness of incumbents.
TurboTax, Wealthsimple Tax, and H&R Block are transactional: users show up in March–April, file, and vanish. Nobody owns "what should I do in September to owe less in April." RRSP-vs-FHSA decisions, capital-gains timing, and quarterly-instalment planning genuinely happen year-round, and the simulators target exactly those moments. If the product earns 12-months-a-year engagement, it also earns a defensible subscription ($9.99/mo) instead of a once-a-year $30 — that's the difference between a feature and a company.

PRO — The Decision Simulator is the most differentiated feature on either site.
"Model this RRSP contribution before you make it and see the refund impact" is concrete, quantified, and not well-served by incumbents (TurboTax has a crude version; Wealthsimple's is thin). It is also mostly deterministic math on published brackets — meaning it can be built accurately *without* the liability exposure of a free-form AI copilot. This should be the wedge, not the copilot.

PRO — One brand, one product is strictly better than two sites.
Two separate Netlify properties with slightly different names (taxhealth vs copilot) dilutes an unknown brand that already has zero trust. Merging removes user confusion, doubles down SEO on one domain, and lets the score write directly into the user's dashboard profile — the questionnaire answers become onboarding data, cutting the platform's cold-start problem.

PRO — The compliance-aware tone is a real asset.
The Tax Health site already carries the right disclaimers (educational estimate, not advice, not CRA-affiliated), and the dashboard leads with plain-language security commitments (encryption, no data selling, deletion rights). In a category where the product ingests SINs and income data, sounding trustworthy from day one is not cosmetic — it is a conversion requirement. Most demo-stage startups get this wrong; this one didn't.

PRO — Canada is a smaller, winnable market with a live catalyst.
~30M T1 returns per year, only a handful of serious software players, and the CRA is actively expanding automatic/simplified filing for low-income filers — which pressures incumbents' low end and rewards products that add value *beyond* filing (planning, optimization). A planning-first product is positioned on the right side of that shift; a filing-only product is not.

3. CONS — THE HARD REALITIES

CON — You cannot file taxes without NETFILE certification, and you don't have it.
The "File" step in the six-stage workflow is the entire promise of the product, and it requires CRA NETFILE software certification: a full T1 calculation engine covering hundreds of forms and schedules, provincial variants (and Quebec's separate TP1 via Revenu Québec if you want that market), annual re-certification every tax year, and a months-long test cycle against CRA test suites. This is a 12–18 month, multi-person engineering effort *before revenue*, repeated every year as tax law changes. The demo skips this entirely. Until certification exists, "$29.99 Premium Filing" is a price for a product that cannot legally deliver its core action.

CON — Your strongest competitor is free, trusted, and already does most of this.
Wealthsimple Tax is $0 (pay-what-you-want), NETFILE-certified, pulls slips automatically via CRA Auto-fill My Return, has an optimizer for RRSP/donations/medical, and sits inside an app millions of Canadians already trust with their money. TurboTax owns the "complex return" segment and the retail mindshare. The demo's headline features — upload T4, estimate refund, find missed deductions — are **table stakes the incumbents ship today for free**. "+$420 medical expenses found" is not a moat when Wealthsimple's optimizer does a version of it at $0. The only claims on either site that Wealthsimple does *not* substantially cover are the year-round simulators and the health score.

CON — Document upload / OCR is solving a solved problem.
CRA Auto-fill My Return delivers T4, T5, T3, T5008, RRSP, and T2202 slips directly into certified software with one CRA login — no photos, no OCR, no errors. A demo whose centerpiece is "upload your T4 and our AI reads it" is worse UX than the incumbent standard. OCR only matters for what AFR can't pull: medical receipts, donation receipts, self-employment expenses, rent. If OCR stays in the product, it must be repositioned around those — otherwise it's engineering spend on a feature that loses to a CRA API.

CON — The AI Copilot is the biggest liability surface and the least defensible feature.
A chatbot answering tax questions in plain language will sometimes be confidently wrong. When it's wrong about a real filing, the user faces CRA reassessment, interest, and penalties — and screenshots of bad advice will circulate. Disclaimers reduce legal exposure but not reputational damage, and errors-and-omissions insurance for AI-generated tax guidance is expensive and unproven. Meanwhile the copilot itself is a thin wrapper over a foundation model that TurboTax (Intuit Assist) and every incumbent can and does replicate with more training data and bigger legal budgets. High risk, low defensibility — the worst quadrant.

CON — The demo shows fabricated precision, which is a trust time-bomb.
"82/100," "$2,431 refund, high confidence," "+$420 opportunity" are hardcoded numbers with no engine behind them. If marketing or investor conversations lean on this specificity before the backend can actually produce it, the gap between promise and delivery becomes the story. The Tax Health site's honest "rough illustration" framing is right; the dashboard's confident numbers contradict it. Pick one register — and in tax, it must be the honest one.

CON — Revenue is brutally seasonal and the pricing is squeezed from both ends.
$29.99/return competes against $0 (Wealthsimple) below and brand-plus-handholding (TurboTax, H&R Block) above — the classic dead middle. The $9.99/month subscription is the escape route, but a $120/year tax subscription must deliver visible value in the 10 months nobody thinks about taxes, which the simulators only partly cover today. Realistic assumption: most users will take Free + file once, and convert to paid at low single-digit rates. Model the business on that, not on optimistic attach rates.

CON — Trust is the binding constraint and you have none yet.
This product asks a stranger for their SIN, income, investments, and medical history. Canadians hand that to CRA-certified brands or to a human at a desk. A Netlify demo with no company registration, no SOC 2, no PIPEDA/Quebec Law 25 posture, and no NETFILE badge starts below zero. Security *claims* on a static page are marketing; the audit trail behind them is the product. Budget real money and calendar time for it.

CON — Two-frontend merge is the easy part; the sites share no data model.
The questionnaire and the dashboard were built as separate demos. Merging them properly means one identity system, one tax-profile schema that both the score and the filing engine read from, and consistent numbers everywhere (the score's illustrative dollars must reconcile with the platform's engine-computed dollars or users will notice). Bolting the quiz onto the dashboard without a shared model recreates the inconsistency inside one domain.

4. RISK REGISTER — WHAT KILLS THIS COMPANY

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
NETFILE certification takes longer / costs more than planned; miss a tax season	High	Fatal for filing revenue that year	Start certification scoping now; consider launching planning-only (no filing) for season one, or filing a deliberately narrow return profile (simple T4 employees) first
Wealthsimple ships year-round planning features	Medium–High	Erases the differentiator	Speed + depth: own RRSP/FHSA/instalment planning for self-employed and investors, segments Wealthsimple's free tier serves worst
Copilot gives materially wrong advice that costs a user money	High over time	Reputational; possible legal	Constrain copilot to retrieval over CRA-published guidance with citations; route anything advisory to deterministic calculators; E&O insurance; log everything
Privacy incident with SIN/financial data	Low–Medium	Fatal	PIPEDA + Quebec Law 25 compliance before launch, data minimization (don't store what AFR can re-fetch), SOC 2 roadmap
CRA expands free automatic filing further	Medium	Compresses the low end	Already mitigated by planning-first positioning — lean into it
Seasonal cash flow starves the company May–January	High	Slow death	Subscription must carry off-season value: instalment reminders, mid-year checkups, RRSP-deadline planning, audit-response help

5. WHAT WOULD MAKE THIS ACTUALLY WORK

- **Merge, but re-order the roadmap.** Ship as one product in this sequence: (1) Tax Health Score + deterministic simulators (no certification needed, real value, collects emails and tax profiles); (2) CRA Auto-fill integration + planning dashboard; (3) NETFILE filing, initially for simple returns only; (4) copilot, last and most constrained.
- **Pick a wedge segment instead of "Canadian tax filers."** Self-employed / gig workers and new investors (FHSA-age, first capital gains) are underserved by free tools, have year-round tax anxiety, and will pay. "Everyone who files a T1" is a positioning that loses to free.
- **Reposition OCR around what Auto-fill can't pull** — medical, donations, business expenses, rent — and market it as "the shoebox killer," not "upload your T4."
- **Make the score real before making it loud.** Back the Tax Health Score with the same engine as the simulators so its dollar figures are defensible; keep the educational disclaimer, drop fake precision.
- **Treat certification and compliance as the product for the next 12 months.** The frontend is done enough. Every week spent polishing the dashboard instead of the T1 engine, AFR integration, and privacy posture pushes the real launch back a season — and in tax, a season is a year.
- **Decide Quebec explicitly.** Separate TP1 filing, French-language requirements, and Law 25 obligations roughly double compliance scope. Launching rest-of-Canada first is a legitimate and probably correct

choice — but make it a decision, not an accident.

6. VERDICT

Merge the two sites: yes, clearly. One brand, score-as-funnel, platform-as-product is the right architecture, and year-round planning is a real gap in the Canadian market.

But the current approach over-invests in the parts that don't decide the outcome. Both demos are frontend expressions of features incumbents already give away, wrapped around the two hardest problems in the category — a certified tax engine and consumer trust — which are currently at 0%. The honest read: this works only if the next year is spent on the unglamorous layer (T1 engine, NETFILE, AFR, PIPEDA/Law 25) while the merged frontend launches early in its certification-free form (score + simulators) to build an audience. If the plan instead is to keep expanding dashboard features and add "AI" breadth before the engine exists, the realistic outcome is a beautiful demo that never files a return.

Prepared as an internal strategy document. Figures cited from the two demo sites are illustrative demo values, not audited claims. Regulatory details (NETFILE certification, CRA Auto-fill scope, Quebec Law 25) should be re-verified against current CRA / Revenu Québec published requirements before committing the roadmap.